

safety is something that happens between your ears, not something you hold in your hands

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Sense & Licence

Strict driving tests alone can't make roads safe

Last Sunday, a truck ran over pilgrims in Gwalior, killing 15. Same day, a car crushed eight workers resting by the road in Sangrur, Punjab. Reminders, in case you needed them, that India's roads count among the most dangerous places in the world. Govt's brought many measures to curb the toll, without much success, as road fatalities have jumped from 146,133 in 2015 to 183,382 in 2025 – roughly 21 every hour. You might say it's because traffic has increased tremendously. But consider that UK had 7,343 road deaths in 1934, with 2.5mn vehicles. Seventy years later, the number of vehicles had increased to 30mn, yet deaths were down to 3,221.



More traffic shouldn't necessarily mean greater risk, if people obey rules. So it's good that govt plans to make driving licence tests more stringent. You might soon need to score 75% in online safe-driving assessments, up from 60% now. Will this end dangerous driving? Probably not. Vietnam has one of the toughest driving tests in the world, requiring 91% marks, but its roads are still dangerous. The road fatality rate there, per WHO, is 13 per 1L population; India's is 16.2. Singapore does not have the toughest driving test, but its roads are the safest, with only 1.4 fatalities per 1L population.

To make roads safer, India needs two things: attitudinal change and strict enforcement. Roads can't be safe if every user assumes they have the right of way, and expects others to compensate for their mistakes. But attitudes won't change without enforcement, which isn't happening. Early this month, SC heard that e-challans worth ₹23,000cr remain unpaid across states. On Friday, **TOI** reported that a Delhi-registered BMW has 42 challans for driving without PUCC. This is sheer impunity. No change is possible when transgressors know the law will wink at them indulgently.

Trump Whisperers

Tech billionaires having all his ear, is risky

Per Trump, he was all set to make Atlantic Ocean into Trump Ocean, except Pichai said, please, please don't do it. Maybe the Don is just joking. He does make things up sometimes. Still, isn't it a very Sundar idea? That the App-solute Rulers can prevail where the institutions haven't. That they can move fast and prevent the worst Trump things. Imagine this as the new Silicon Valley motto: Don't ask what you can disrupt, ask what you can stop the president from disrupting.



When he is restricting immigration, Pichai, Nadella, Musk need to put up bigger bars than a polite cough. He wants factories, big factories, beautiful factories, so tell him every specialised international hire helps support a much larger operation. Explain that a tariff cannot transport any industry to America. When he comes after research funding, turn his yuuuugitude against him: "We're losing to China, tremendously." When he wants to rename a river, suggest a creek.

In a democracy, we expect institutions to restrain executive power. Outsourcing that job to CEOs and promoters with fantastic net worth, is not without risk. Nobody's elected them, to decide which presidential impulses are sensible. When they talk Trump out of something, they may not be protecting America from a bad idea, but only their company from the consequences. Worry is that the public won't get to know which is which. If tech billionaires are expected to restrain the president, who restrains these billionaires?